

The Fine Print

Take a second look at your warranty before buying computer hardware. You'll be glad you did, especially when your computer goes kaput!

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You're as pleased as punch with the 11-month-old computer you bought at a throwaway price. But all of a sudden tragedy strikes—the motherboard goes for a toss. Nothing's working, and as a last ditch effort, you dig your warranty card out assuming that getting a replacement will be smooth sailing. But it doesn't quite work that way. The person you got the fantastic deal from is nowhere to be found and your 'warranty' won't cut ice with the service centre. After several calls and trips, you throw up your hands in despair wishing you had paid more attention to your warranty at the time of purchase.

Does it really matter?

This situation may sound familiar to a lot of those who've had PC components such as the motherboard or hard disk changed. While some of you might have had absolutely no problems with getting components replaced or serviced, others may have a different tale to narrate.

The not-so-good experiences range from not being given a warranty at all to some assemblers shutting shop and taking off before the warranty expires, often leaving customers in the lurch. "We paid a much higher price than what was quoted in the advertisements in the newspapers and insisted on a written warranty from the assembler, but were told we'd have to pay around Rs 4,000 more if we wanted a warranty," say Gary and Gerald Misquitta from Mumbai who purchased their computer two years back from a person who was recommended by their friends. "So we went ahead and purchased the computer without the warranty. However, a week later when our hard disk crashed, he did give us a replacement." But four months later when they



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar